

JFSN Oral History

Jeffrey Francis Stanley Neumann

Primary source record of conversations about a creative life.

Do not edit or summarize — preserve exactly as written.

Date: 2026-06-09

Sessions captured: 2026-06-08, 2026-06-09, 2026-06-09 (session 2)

Archive: jfsn.com

This document is a living record. It is not finished. Add to it after every oral history session.

Preserve Jeff's words exactly where possible. Mark paraphrased content clearly. Do not improve, editorialize, or interpret without labeling it as interpretation.

If a quote is uncertain, mark it [approximate]. If it is verbatim, leave it unmarked.

1. Origins — Art School and Early Ambition

Jeff attended the Cleveland Institute of Art. He went intending to become a fine artist. That was the plan.

At CIA, he encountered materials that became lasting obsessions: prism paper (holographic, iridescent, surface that shifts with light), vacuum-formed plastic, old fluorescent and CFL tubes, sheets of glass. Rauschenberg was on the walls — combines built from anything. The idea that found material was as valid as paint. That permission never left.

He expected the art world might become a major part of his professional life. It didn't.

WHAT HE WANTED:

"Wanted to be a fine artist."

WHAT HE THOUGHT HE WAS SUPPOSED TO WANT:

Money. Fame. Recognition. But in his own words, those were things you were *supposed* to want — not necessarily what actually drove him.

2. The Rauschenberg Realization

Over decades of research, Jeff gradually discovered that Robert Rauschenberg had already explored much of the territory he thought was his own. This was not a single moment of discovery. It crept in slowly — through books, research, exposure over time.

The realization: the work he was making was not groundbreaking. Someone had already been there.

This did not stop him.

KEY QUOTE:

"Kept going."

WHAT REMAINS UNKNOWN:

Why he kept going after this realization is the most important unanswered question in the archive. The session ended before he answered it. Return to this.

3. Why He Kept Making — The Central Unanswered Question

This is the thread that matters most. It has not been fully answered.

What has been captured so far:

He always believed he was good at it. Had an eye for it. Not from external validation — just knowing himself.

The belief in his own eye appears to have been a constant, even when recognition didn't come.

Money and fame were things he was *supposed* to want, not what actually drove him.

Whether he would have made the work even if no one ever saw it: *"yes, it might be worth it in the end =)"*

WHAT 'WORTH IT' MEANS TO HIM:

Not yet answered. The session was moving toward this.

KEY EXCHANGE (2026-06-09):

Q: Would you still have spent fifty years making it if nobody had ever seen it?

"yes, it might be worth it in the end =)"

Q: Worth it for what?

"money/fame?" [said as if testing the expected answer, not claiming it]

Q: Did you ever actually want those things, or does it feel like you were supposed to want them?

"you were supposed to want them"

Q: So what was it actually for?

"i thought I was always good at it / had an eye for it"

UNANSWERED:

Was there ever a time he doubted the eye? Did he ever lose it, or feel like he had? Session ended before answer.

4. Art at the Edges of Life

During the career and family years, making art moved to the margins. It did not disappear.

Jeff worked as a product designer and creative director for decades. Marriage. Children. Bills. The ordinary weight of a life. The studio work continued in the gaps — evenings, weekends, whatever time was left.

HIS ACCOUNT OF RETURNING AFTER THE FAMILY YEARS:

When the kids were heading to college, he started making again more seriously — after hours, with whatever he could find or afford.

ON MATERIALS DURING THOSE YEARS:

"Art supplies were always too expensive."

CDs, computer floppies, keyboards, dollar store finds, tape, prism paper. Not art supplies. Things that still had a life left in them.

KEY QUOTE:

"Something that still had a life left in it."

HIS FRAMING OF THOSE THIRTY-ODD YEARS:

"Ha Ha Ha — 30 odd years ago and still making artwork."

5. Returning After Retirement

Around 2020, Jeff retired. The creative work moved back toward the center of life.

Since retiring, he has been wondering whether it was worth it — whether anyone cares or wants to see the work.

KEY QUOTE:

"Getting old / no one really cares or wants to see it."

This is not despair. It is an honest accounting. It sits alongside the fact that he is still making things most days.

The archive emerged from this moment — looking back across fifty years of making and deciding the surviving work deserved preservation.

6. The Loss — Water Damage and the Lost Works

A friend called. Jeff went to see if he could save anything. He was told to stay away — bed bugs. He saw the work on the curb from about six feet away, waiting for the garbage truck.

An estimated 500 to 1,000 works were lost. There was no inventory. No photographs of most of them. No record.

KEY QUOTES:

"Saw it out front waiting for the garbage men to take them all away."

"From around six feet away on the sidewalk."

"Sad. Enough."

"I made some great large pieces and I thought they were really good."

"Only in one picture."

The lost works include some of what he considered his best pieces. Some exist now only in a single photograph.

WHY THE ARCHIVE EXISTS, IN HIS WORDS:

Built so the work wouldn't disappear twice. And so his family would know what existed — including the pieces that are only in one photograph now.

7. Building the Archive

He built it alone. It took a long time.

"Took a fucking long time. Moments of doubt in the middle."

WHO IT IS FOR:

His daughters' families and their future generations. A practical reference for the physical works they will inherit. Proof that the lost work existed.

8. Guernica — Thirty Years of a Single Reference

Jeff read a book about how Picasso made Guernica. He considered it the most important painting of the twentieth century.

He used it as a direction. A structure to work against. The Guernica series ran for more than thirty years and produced 232 works. He is still reworking old Guernica pieces today.

HIS DESCRIPTION OF WHY GUERNICA:

"Nice and big. Used it as a direction, a structure to work against."

WHAT REMAINS UNKNOWN:

Why Guernica specifically, over thirty years. What kept him returning to it. What he was asking of it that it kept answering. This deserves its own session.

9. Family Collaboration — Grandchildren

For approximately four years, Jeff has been incorporating his grandchildren's drawings into his work.

"Whatever they want to make, and whatever I want to do with it."

The boundary between contributions has become unclear.

KEY QUOTE:

"Getting hard to tell where they end and I begin."

"I think that's right."

WHAT REMAINS UNKNOWN:

Which grandchildren. What specifically they contribute. Whether they know these works exist in the archive. Whether they have seen the finished pieces.

10. On His Own Eye

Jeff has always believed he had an eye for it. This belief was not derived from external recognition — it came from inside.

"Just knowing yourself."

Whether he ever doubted this, or felt he had lost it, is an open question. The session moved toward this and ended.

11. On Incompleteness as Method

When asked whether he ever finished a piece and thought it wasn't good, Jeff said:

"Always have the option to add/subtract — could be unfinished till the end."

Nothing receives a final verdict. The option to return is always open. A piece that isn't working yet is not a failure — it's not done. This appears to be structural, not incidental. The practice stays alive partly because closure is never imposed.

12. A Specific Lost Work — CIA, Late 1970s

One work described in detail:

- Sculpture, made at CIA
- Late 1970s
- Prism paper applied to sections of iron gridwork found in a junkyard
- Something torn from a magazine incorporated
- Approximately 38 inches wide, 24 inches tall, 3–4 inches deep
- Hung on a wall
- Shown at a student show
- Sold

No image exists.

Someone has lived with this piece for nearly fifty years. Jeff does not know where it is.

STATUS OF THIS MEMORY:

Jeff was asked what it felt like when it sold, and declined to answer at that point. The question remains open for a future session.

Unresolved Questions

Priority order for future sessions — for legacy preservation:

1. Why did he keep going after the Rauschenberg realization?

The most important unanswered question. Approach gently. He may not have fully articulated it to himself.

2. Did he ever seriously consider stopping — not just wondering, but deciding?

What stopped him from stopping?

3. Was there ever a time he felt he had lost the eye?

A period of doubt about his own ability?

4. What does 'worth it' mean to him now, at 71?

Not money or fame — so what?

5. Why Guernica, for thirty years?

What did it keep giving him?

6. What does a day of making actually look like?

Studio, kitchen table, materials, process.

7. Which grandchildren? What do they contribute?

Do they know they're in the archive?

8. What is he making right now?

What still pulls at him?

9. What does he want grandchildren to understand that they won't be able to see in the work itself?

10. Does he have regrets about the work he didn't make — not the lost works, but the work he never started?

Archivist Notes

ON JEFF'S VOICE:

Spare. Direct. The power is in brevity and specificity. *'From around six feet away on the sidewalk'* is better than any paragraph about loss. Do not dress it up.

ON THE CENTRAL STORY:

The archive is about persistence. Not success, not recognition, not groundbreaking work. A man who kept making things for fifty years because he believed he had an eye for it and stopping wasn't something he seriously considered. That story is not yet fully told. It may be the most important thing to preserve before it can no longer be asked about.

ON WHAT EXISTS ONLY IN JEFF'S MEMORY:

The reasons. The specifics. The private accounting of what fifty years of making actually meant to him. The catalog preserves the work. Only these sessions can preserve the person behind it.

End of document. Updated 2026-06-09. Add to this after every session.